Creativity is defined as the tendency to generate or recognize ideas, alternatives, or possibilities that may be useful in solving problems, communicating with others, and entertaining ourselves and others.

In order to be creative, you need to be able to view things in new ways or from a different perspective. Among other things, you need to be able to generate new possibilities or new alternatives. Tests of creativity measure not only the number of alternatives that people can generate but the uniqueness of those alternatives. The ability to generate alternatives or to see things uniquely does not occur by change

Tapping into your innate creativity requires making changes to what you do at work. You need to break your most destructive, focus-killing habits, such as spending a large portion of your day (or weekend) on email or giving in to persistent distractions. To start, give yourself time to quietly think and reflect. Practicing mindfulness can be extremely helpful for this because it aids cognitive functioning. The other thing to work on is managing stress about your deficiencies and failures. This may be most difficult for achievement-oriented business people, but no one can possibly be creative without failing — a lot. Finally, focus on what makes you happy at work. The positive emotions you feel when you are connected to your personal and organizational purpose will help you stay grounded and creative, even when things are tough.

Everyone is creative. Somehow, creativity became synonymous with “art,” but that’s not the case. Creativity encompasses innovation and problem-solving, which is why it’s the top-desired skill among employers.

The good news is that everyone has an innate creative impulse. The bad news is that it’s often buried under many layers of inhibition and self-doubt. Even creative professionals question themselves in a world full of rejection and trolls. All these factors can lead to creative block, in which your skills are temporarily locked up.

If this sounds like you, don’t worry. There’s a way to unlock your creativity.

Step 1. Brainstorm

Need to solve a problem? Have an idea you want to express but aren't sure how? Brainstorming is the solution to both. Get out some scratch paper and a pencil or pen, find a quiet place, and just start jotting down ideas. The more, the better. If you struggle with this, use some of these prompts:

What does this project remind me of?

What are the different aspects of this project?

Why is this project important?

Have I done a project like this before?

Who inspires me in this project?

By following these prompts, you can make a list of motivations, characteristics, and inspirations that will kick-start your approach to the project.

Step 2. Make a Worry List

Many self-help gurus place too much emphasis on "positive thinking" and gratitude. If you're creatively locked up, singing your own praises won't do the trick. You must acknowledge what you're anxious about so that you can break free from these limitations.

Get out another piece of paper and start your worry list. Ask yourself these questions:

What am I afraid of with this project?

Has something bad happened with a similar project?

Why don't I feel confident about this project?

Are there people criticizing me about this project?

You might be surprised to discover that the real reason you have creative block or don't feel creative is because of your self-doubt and self-criticism, not because of any lack of skills! Let's fix that.

Step 3. Make a Solution List

Now, it’s time to think positively. For each worry that you listed, identify a solution for the problem. Think of what would make you stop worrying and start feeling confident. Then, put that into action. This is also a good time to think about people who inspire and motivate you. For example, if you’re struggling to get your writing done because someone insulted your work, you must acknowledge the worry (“I’m a bad writer”), then find the solution (“I enjoy writing and will continue to improve,” “someone I admire appreciates my work,” etc.)

Step 4. Start Creating

It’s easy to procrastinate if you’re creatively locked. This unlocking process should result in your feeling ready to create. Don’t let the moment pass you by: Set aside your lists and start putting your ideas into action. Don’t worry about editing, pitching, promoting, or whatever comes after. Just start getting your ideas onto paper (or a digital file, or wherever).

Step 5. Reflect On Your Work

By now, those creative juices should be flowing. Stay in it for a while, then take a rest to avoid burnout and give yourself a chance to reflect on your work. How do you feel? What’s next for the project? Keep yourself on track by regularly taking breaks to reflect and adjust. This technique helps keep you creative without draining your mind and energy!

1. Finding Problems (Preparation)

Creative people don't sit and allow problems to surface. Instead, they scan their environment for potential issues, and they see this as time well spent. Also, they're excited by the opportunity to change things. They aren't intimidated by change; they embrace it.

To develop your creative skills, you need to adopt a positive attitude towards change, and take an active role in identifying opportunities and looking for potential issues. To do this, challenge your business processes and look for bottlenecks in these processes.

Keep up-to-date with customer experiences and expectations, and try to spot problems from other people's perspectives.

Also, engage in benchmarking to find out how well others are addressing similar issues, and look at the issue from a wide range of perspectives. Then, analyze your findings to ensure that a real problem does exist. This fact-finding activity can save you a great deal of time later on, and will help ensure that you only act on the most relevant problems and issues.

Look first for problems and potential issues that interest you. These are the things you'll be most motivated to pursue when you're learning to solve problems creatively. Then, as you become more confident, challenge yourself to investigate issues that are more complex.

2. Gathering and Reflecting on Information (Incubation)

When you have a potential issue or problem, gather as much information about it as you can. As part of this, investigate solutions that have been tried previously (both in your own organization, and in other areas), and identify ideas that might have surfaced, but were never acted on.

At this stage it's also a good idea to step away from the problem for a while, and allow new thoughts and ideas to enter your mind. When we concentrate on one issue for too long there is a tendency to latch onto one or two ideas, and this can block other good ideas. (One of the benefits of being proactive in your problem-finding is that you have time to incubate ideas, rather than being pressurized to find an immediate solution to a problem.)

3. Problem Exploration (Insight)

Once you've identified and verified your problem, you can figure out what's really going on. Often, the initial problem that you identified will turn out to be a symptom of a deeper problem. Therefore, identifying the root cause of the problem is extremely important.

While creativity may invoke ideas of spontaneous insight and far-out inspiration, the truth is that being creative in the workplace is rooted in a practical understanding of the situation at hand.

Don't, however, be so practical that you become negative. What often separates creative people from others is the ability to see past potential barriers, and believe in their insights. For instance, you could easily dismiss a great insight by saying, "Oh that could never be the problem!" But, you won't ever know if something is contributing to a problem unless you allow yourself to explore the possibility. That's what creative problem exploration is all about – being open to all ideas and possibilities.

4. Generating and Evaluating Ideas (Evaluation)

When you have clear insight into the cause of the issue, you can move onto generating ideas for a solution. Here you want to look for as many ways to inspire ideas as possible. Brainstorming, Reverse Brainstorming and Starbursting are popular for this, however these can be undermined by problems with group dynamics. Techniques like Brainwriting , Round-Robin Brainstorming and the Charette Procedure can help you circumvent common problems.

You can also enrich your ideas by using tools like the Six Thinking Hats, Random Input , the Reframing Matrix and Metaphorical Thinking to look at problems from different perspectives.

Obviously not all of the ideas you have will be practical or possible. So, as part of this step in the creativity process, you need to decide which criteria you'll use to evaluate

your ideas. (Without a solid evaluation process, you'll be prone to choosing a solution that is perhaps too cautious.)

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Creativity isn’t necessarily a characteristic you’re born with; it's a trait that can be honed through habit. With the right practice and persistence, you can rewire your brain to be creative

The best way build your creative mind is through practice. Research shows that creative practice reduces stress and improves problem-solving.

Start rewiring your brain with these nine life-changing habits, and soon you’ll be bursting with innovative and creative ideas.

1. Mindful observation.

Our ability to create begins with observing the world around us. How we perceive our surroundings and our environment fuels our creativity. This begins with, mindful observation, or noticing and appreciating the details of your surroundings.

By improving your observation skills, you’ll tap into your creative energy and discover nuances and details you hadn’t noticed before. This will open your mind to new possibilities and help you build a repertoire of experiences that can ignite innovation.

It’s easy to become overwhelmed by the staggering amount of visual information that surrounds us. Start by focusing on areas where you want to make improvements. The world is full of interesting patterns and connections. Try to spot the relationships between things. Look for how things form or “click” together, and how people and things affect one another. These connections can be fuel for ideas and spark your creative process.

3. Take a creative stroll.

We all know a sedentary life is bad for your health, and it turns out exercise is also good for your creative thinking. Simply getting up and going for a walk will improve brain function and boost your creativity. One study found that walking benefited creative brainstorming and enhanced “divergent” or unconventional thinking.

You can also turn a walk into an opportunity to practice mindful observation. Watch people in a crowded area. Take mental note of things that catch your eye and make a quick sketch when you get home. Or take photos along the way and create a weekly collage of the things you see. Try taking a “soundwalk,” in which you focus on the sounds around you and where they’re coming from.

4. Recharge your curiosity.

Creativity thrives on curiosity. Our ability to wonder, to dig into something and search for answers, ignites our creativity and fuels our innovative thoughts. But our thirst for knowledge can dwindle over time. We stop asking and begin accepting. Try sparking your imagination and creativity by asking questions.

Start living a curiosity-driven life. What piques your interest? Delve into it; examine and research it. See where your line of thinking takes you. You may discover that you thrive on the process of discovery. The more you know, the more your mind is awakened, and the more you want to learn. This will open your mind to new possibilities others simply cannot see.

5. Try some blue sky thinking.

Blue sky thinking means to completely free your mind and brainstorm without limitations. It means moving beyond the standards, boundaries and thresholds that we have built for ourselves and generating ideas that aren’t bound by cost, effort, time, technology or resources. It means freeing yourself of constraints, assumptions and self-limiting beliefs. It’s a great way to ignite your creative engine and spur innovative thoughts.

Start with a clear question with a specific goal. Remember, there are no bad ideas, so don't berate yourself for a thought you might think is dumb. This is giving yourself the ability to think out of the box and explore ideas without dismissing them too quickly.

The idea is to unburden yourself with constraints that bog down your thinking, so be creative and wacky. When you're done, look through the ideas. You can weed out impractical ideas or those that aren't focused on the goal, but there may be nuggets of thought that can help you find achievable, pertinent concepts you can build on.

6. Incorporate "design thinking" into your creative process.

Design thinking is an approach to practical and creative problem-solving. It starts with empathy -- understanding what the end user wants, their constraints and desires. Because design thinking focuses on humans and understanding people's needs, and then coming up with effective solutions to meet those needs, it can be applied to nearly any field.

The design thinking process consists of 5 stages: empathize, define, ideate, prototype and test. It marries both creativity and critical-thinking skills. It requires designers to generate lots of ideas and prototype them, so they become comfortable with failure.

It forces you to keep your mind open, to try out many ideas early on, so you don't get too invested in just one. The process harnesses creativity through inquiry. At its core, it's a structured, systematic way of solving problems.

8. Take time to daydream.

Allowing yourself time to "space out" and let your mind wander can boost creativity. Researchers have found that daydreaming can lead to creative problem-solving. When your mind wanders, it accesses memories, emotions and random bits of stored

knowledge. The key to using mind-wandering effectively is to direct it toward an area you're looking for inspiration in.

Focused daydreaming requires you to first research and explore the problem or issue you're hoping to solve. Having a foundation of knowledge to draw on is important, so the subconscious mind can ponder it all. Then you'll need to find a way to "switch off" and let your mind go.

Pay close attention to any ideas you come up with, and jot them down. A few ways to create a daydreaming mind include going for a walk, taking a shower or bath, going for a bicycle ride or lying awake at night or in the morning.

8. Reframe failure: Creative people are less afraid of making mistakes than most people. They realize that creativity is a volume business -- that many experiments are needed and that trial and error comes with the territory. When Thomas Edison was asked how it felt to fail 800 times before coming up with tungsten as the filament for the light bulb, his reply said it all: "Fail? I didn't fail once. I learned 800 times, what didn't work." *How can you launch more experiments? How can you embrace failure more than you currently do?*

13. See through others' eyes: One of the biggest obstacles to creativity is our odd little habit of viewing everything through our own eyes/lenses/filters. Addicted to our own point of view, we tend to be constrained by our habitual ways of perceiving. The simplest way to free yourself from this constraint is to look at your problem, project, or opportunity through the eyes of someone else. *What if Willie Nelson was responsible for solving your problem? Stevie Wonder? Rosa Parks? Oprah Winfrey? How would any one of these people go about it? And what clues do you get from their approach?*

14. Pay attention to your subconscious: Many brilliant ideas come to people off line, in dreams, or in surprise moments when they're not trying to figure things out. What happen is this: the conscious, problem-solving part of our mind hits a wall and gets stuck. That's when the problem gets turned over to our subconscious mind. That's how Elias Howe's invention of the lock stitch sewing machine happened. That's how Rene Descartes came up with the Scientific Method. And that's what Seymour Cray, the inventor of the Cray Supercomputer, attributed his success to -- the ability to walk away

from a problem and let his subconscious mind do the work. *Where and when do you get your best ideas away from work?*